the elected parliament and dismissed the government. An entirely new system called ‘panchayat’ was introduced, based on a hierarchical system of village, district, and national councils, with the king at the top. The CPN was banned again, this time with all other political parties.

The 1960 royal coup, the ban, and especially the Sino-Soviet conflict in the 1960s, caused the first of many splits in Nepal’s communist movement. Its general secretary, Keshar Jung Rayamajhi, who was attending a meeting of communist parties in Moscow at the time, actually supported the monarch. A CPN plenum held in Darbhanga in India removed Rayamajhi from his position in March 1961. The following year, he was expelled from the CPN, but, refusing to accept the party’s decision, he formed his own communist party. At the same time, while the ‘mainstream’ CPN remained loyal to Moscow, Comrade PL and his more radical comrades sided with China in the Sino-Soviet conflict. Thus the Communist Party of Nepal (Pushpa Lal) was born, and Comrade PL was its leader until his death in 1978.

The Naxalite-inspired rebellion in Jhapa in the early 1970s gave birth to yet another party, the Communist Party of Nepal (Marxist-Leninist) (CPN-ML). Formed in 1978, it became active in the area around Biratnagar in the southeastern plains. In the same year, another similar faction of the pro-China movement in the southeast formed the Nepal Workers’ and Peasants Organisation. Yet another communist faction emerged from the turbulent 1970s. It was modelled after India’s ‘independent’ communist party, the Communist Party of India (Marxist), and led by Manmohan Adhikari, a former CPN general secretary and erstwhile follower of Comrade PL. It named itself the Communist Party of Nepal (Marxist).

The troubled kingdom was thrown into a new crisis in the spring of 1990, when a popular uprising, called ‘Jan Andolan’ or people’s movement, forced King Birendra, Mahendra’s eldest son and successor, to agree to abolish what amounted to an absolute monarchy. More than 500 demonstrators were killed in violent clashes with the police in Kathmandu before the king eventually gave in to popular demands for an end to the old system. A multiparty system was introduced and elections were held to form a parliament in May 1991. The communist parties returned from underground. At first, even the most radical of them participated in the democratic process. Their front organization, the Samyukta Jana Morcha (United People’s Front, UPF) emerged as the third largest party in the 1991